

Comprehensive Study Notes

Chapter Fifteen — Śaṅkara Vedānta (Part I)

Covering: Metaphysical Views; Śaṅkara's dialectical criticism of Sāṅkhya, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, the doctrine of God as efficient cause only, Brahma-pariṇāma-vāda, Jainism, and Buddhism (Sarvāstivāda, Kṣaṇabhaṅga-vāda, Vijñānavāda, Śūnyavāda). [Māyā-Brahman section reserved for Part II]

I. METAPHYSICAL VIEWS

Radhakrishnan's assessment, quoted approvingly by Sharma, sets the tone: it is impossible to read Śaṅkara without being conscious of contact with “a mind of a very fine penetration and profound spirituality” — a philosophy that “stands forth complete, needing neither a before nor an after,” whose “penetrating light... never leaves us where we were.”

The Nature of Ultimate Reality

Ultimate Reality, for Śaṅkara, is Ātman or Brahman, which is Pure Consciousness (jñāna-svarūpa) — or, put more precisely, Consciousness of the Pure Self (svarūpa-jñāna). This Reality is nirguṇa (devoid of all attributes) and nirviśeṣa (devoid of all categories of the intellect). Brahman associated with its own potency (śakti) — Māyā or Mūlāvidyā — appears as the qualified Brahman: saguna, or saviśeṣa, or apara-Brahma. This qualified Brahman is Īśvara, the Lord, who is the creator, preserver and destroyer of this world — a world which is, in the final analysis, His own appearance.

Jīva as Subject-Object Complex

The individual self, Jīva, is analysed as a subject-object complex:

- Subject-element: Pure Consciousness, technically called the Sākṣin (the Witness).
- Object-element: the internal organ, the antaḥkaraṇa, which is bhautika (composed of all five elements, with a predominance of tejas/fire). This is why the internal organ is always active except in deep sleep or exceptional states such as swoon or trance.

The source of the internal organ is Avidyā, and it is this Avidyā which is responsible for individuality as such. In perception, when the internal organ, through a sense-organ, comes into contact with an object, it assumes the very ‘form’ of that object — this assumed form is called the vṛtti, the mode of the internal organ. The vṛtti, when illumined or ‘inspired’ by the Sākṣin, becomes empirical knowledge.

Across the three states of experience, the internal organ behaves differently:

- Waking state — the internal organ is aided by the senses.
- Dream state — the internal organ functions entirely by itself, without the senses.

- Deep sleep — the internal organ is lost in its cause, Avidyā; yet even here individuality persists, because the Sākṣin remains associated with Avidyā.

Liberation occurs when Avidyā is destroyed by Jñāna (right knowledge), and the Sākṣin is realized to be nothing but the Brahman that it always, in truth, already was.

The Nature of Māyā or Avidyā

Māyā or Avidyā is not pure illusion, nor is it mere absence of knowledge. It is positive wrong knowledge — described as ‘a cross of the real and the unreal’ (satyāṇṛte mithunī kṛtya). Precisely because of this hybrid status, Māyā is strictly indescribable (anirvachanīya):

- It is not existent, for existence belongs to Brahman alone.
- It is not non-existent, for it is responsible for the very appearance of Brahman as the world.
- It cannot be both existent and non-existent at once, since this conception is self-contradictory.

It is therefore called neither real nor unreal (sadasadvilakṣaṇa) — false, or mithyā. Yet it is not a bare non-entity like a hare's horn (tuchchhā): it is positive (bhāvarūpa), and is also termed superimposition (adhyāsa).

The Shell-Silver Analogy

Śaṅkara's standard illustration: a shell is mistaken for silver. The shell is the ground on which the silver is superimposed; when right knowledge (pramā) arises, the error (bhrānti or bhrama) vanishes. The relation between the shell and the illusory silver is neither identity nor difference nor both — it is unique, and is technically named tādātmya (non-difference). By exact analogy, Brahman is the ground on which the world appears through Māyā. When right knowledge dawns and the essential unity of the jīva with the Paramātmā is realized, Māyā or Avidyā vanishes.

The Phenomenal Reality of the World

Śaṅkara insists that, from the phenomenal standpoint, the world is quite real — not an illusion but a practical reality (vyāvahārika sattā). He distinguishes the dream state sharply from the waking state: things seen in a dream are quite true as long as the dream lasts, and are sublated only upon waking. Likewise, the world is real for as long as true knowledge has not dawned. But there is a crucial asymmetry: dreams are private, being the creation of the individual jīva (jīvasṛṣṭā), whereas the world is public, being the creation of Īśvara (Īśvarasṛṣṭā).

The jīva, ignorant of the essential unity underlying all things, takes plurality/diversity to be true and wrongly regards himself as an independent agent and enjoyer. Avidyā operates through two powers: it conceals the underlying unity (āvaraṇa) and it projects names and forms (vikṣepa). Īśvara, by contrast, never misses the underlying unity — Māyā exercises only its projective (vikṣepa) aspect over Him, never its concealing (āvaraṇa) aspect. The Highest Brahman (Para-Brahma) functions as both the locus (āshraya) and the object (viṣaya) of Māyā.

When the jīva realizes this essential unity through knowledge alone (karma being merely subsidiary to this end), liberation is attained — jīvan-mukti (liberation here and now, while still embodied), with videha-mukti (final release) following after the death of

the body.

Śaṅkara's Relation to Buddhism — A Preliminary Note

Sharma draws attention to a striking historical irony: Śaṅkara's philosophy is considerably influenced by Buddhism, and he preserves the best of Mahāyāna within his own system. He freely uses vocabulary common to Mahāyāna literature, especially in his Upaniṣad-Bhāṣyas. Yet outwardly he is an enemy of Buddhism. Where Gauḍapāda had shown love and respect for Mahāyāna, Śaṅkara has nothing but strong and even bitter words for it.

Sharma makes a point of considerable interest: Śaṅkara does not at all criticize the two most important schools of Mahāyāna proper — Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda — in their authentic forms.

- What he criticizes under the name 'Vijñānavāda' is, in fact, Svatantra-Vijñānavāda.
- He summarily dismisses Śūnyavāda as a self-condemned nihilism, treating it as 'below criticism' rather than engaging its real doctrine.

Śaṅkara names three important schools of Buddhism: the Sarvāstivāda, the Vijñānavāda, and the Śūnyavāda. The Sarvāstivāda school of Hīnayāna, according to Śaṅkara, includes both the Vaibhāṣika and the Sautrāntika schools, and this school was already bitterly criticized by the Mahāyānists themselves — so Śaṅkara's criticism of it is not new, though it is correct, faithful, and perfectly justified.

Śaṅkara avoids Śūnyavāda's real content by taking the word 'Śūnya' in its popular sense and easily dismissing Śūnyavāda as nihilism; he does not at all touch real Vijñānavāda. By 'Vijñānavādins' he means the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins, who were his immediate predecessors, and it was easy for him to criticize their doctrine of momentary consciousness. There is no reference anywhere to Asaṅga or Vasubandhu or to their characteristic doctrines, with the solitary exception of the Ālaya-Vijñāna. On the other hand, Śaṅkara quotes verses from Diṇnāga and Dharmakīrti, correctly exposing and criticizing their views, and he also engages the views of Śāntarakṣita, replying to objections Śāntarakṣita himself had raised.

Where Svatantra-Vijñānavāda shares doctrines in common with true Vijñānavāda, Śaṅkara's criticism applies indirectly to Vijñānavāda as well — but here it loses much of its force, because Vijñānavāda regards Consciousness as absolute and permanent (unlike the momentary vijñāna of the Svatantra school). Sharma concludes that Śaṅkara represents a definite advance on Vasubandhu, as well as on Gauḍapāda, who himself agrees with Vasubandhu in many respects. [This point is developed fully in section IX(d) below.]

II. CRITICISM OF THE PRAKṚTI-PARIṆĀMA-VĀDA OF SĀṆKHYA

Point of Agreement

Śaṅkara agrees with Sāṅkhya on one fundamental point: the design, harmony, and order manifest in the universe must presuppose a single cause that is eternal and unlimited. His disagreement begins over the nature of that cause: Sāṅkhya holds it to be the unintelligent Prakṛti; Śaṅkara insists that only the Intelligent Brahman can be such a cause.

Śaṅkara's Arguments Against Unintelligent Prakṛti as First Cause

1. The Argument from Immanent Teleology. How can the immanent teleology visible in nature be explained by an unintelligent Prakṛti? We are entitled to proceed from the finite to the infinite, from the limited to the unlimited, from the peros to the ateros, from the effect to the cause, from plurality to unity. Only the Conscious Brahman, associated with its Māyā-Shakti, can be the creator, preserver and destroyer of this world.
2. The Argument from Design (the Workmen Analogy). Unintelligent Prakṛti is far too poor and powerless to be the cause of this world's order. Just as stones, bricks and mortar cannot fashion themselves into a well-designed building without the help of intelligent workmen, so an unintelligent Pradhāna cannot account for the beauty, symmetry, order and harmony of this great universe, both internal and external.
3. The Argument from the First Impetus. How can Pradhāna explain the original impetus, the first push, the élan that is supposed to disturb the equilibrium of the three guṇas? Mere clay, without a potter, cannot fashion itself into a pot; chariots cannot move without horses.
4. Why Not Frankly Admit a Conscious Source? Why should Sāṅkhya hesitate and admit only that the initial activity comes from the 'mere presence' of Puruṣa (puruṣa-sannidhimātra)? Why not frankly admit that this activity comes from the Conscious Brahman?
5. The Refutation of the Milk-for-the-Calf Analogy. Sāṅkhya argues that just as unintelligent milk flows for the nourishment of the calf, so unintelligent Prakṛti works, unconsciously, for the emancipation of Puruṣa. This is untenable: milk flows because there is a living cow and a living calf, and because there is motherly love in the cow for the calf. Prakṛti, regarded as an absolutely independent entity in itself, cannot be related in any way to the wholly indifferent Puruṣa, who can neither energize nor restrain it. If it could, Prakṛti should sometimes evolve and sometimes not evolve, arbitrarily — which Sāṅkhya cannot explain. Nor can the modification of Prakṛti be compared to grass turning into milk, since grass becomes milk only when it is eaten by a milch cow, not when it lies uneaten, or is eaten by a bull.
6. Unconscious Pradhāna and Indifferent Puruṣa Cannot Together Yield Purpose. Even granting activity to Pradhāna, this cannot explain the teleology that Sāṅkhya takes to be immanent in nature. An unconscious Pradhāna can have no purpose; an indifferent, neutral Puruṣa too can have no purpose. If Sāṅkhya tries to solve this by the simile of Prakṛti and Puruṣa combining like the blind man and the lame man, or like a magnet moving iron, the simile fails: the blind and the lame are both

intelligent and active beings, whereas Prakṛti is unconscious and Puruṣa is indifferent. The magnet-and-iron simile is equally mistaken.

7. The Problem of Perpetual Motion, or None at All. If the mere presence of Puruṣa is sufficient to move the Pradhāna, then — since Puruṣa is always co-present with Prakṛti — there should be perpetual movement: creation would have neither beginning nor end, and the liberation of Puruṣa would become impossible.

8. No Tertium Quid to Relate Two Absolute Principles. Prakṛti and Puruṣa can never really be related. Prakṛti is unconscious, Puruṣa is indifferent, and there is no third principle to relate them. The chasm Sāṅkhya has created by postulating two independent and eternal entities — one subject, one object — can never be bridged from within the system. It must therefore recognize a higher conscious principle which transcends this subject-object duality and yet preserves it at a lower, phenomenal level.

9. The Moral Objection — Vicarious Suffering. By regarding Pradhāna as a mere agent and Puruṣa as a mere enjoyer, Sāṅkhya opens itself to the charge of vicarious suffering, which throws all moral responsibility overboard. Why should Puruṣa suffer for the actions of Pradhāna? And how can it be possible that Prakṛti knows only how to act and not how to enjoy?

The Vedic Basis, and the Reinterpretation of Sāṅkhya Terms

For Śaṅkara, Brahman alone is the cause of the world, and this is universally declared by all the Vedānta texts. Words such as mahat and avyakta, used in certain Upaniṣads (e.g. the Kaṭha), do not denote the Sāṅkhyan mahat and avyakta at all; they simply mean the potentiality of names and forms resting in their cause, Brahman — they are not independent of it. Sāṅkhya and Yoga are generally accepted by the wise as conducive to the highest good, but since they advocate dualism, they cannot be supported by the Shruti as independent systems: the Shruti uses these words only in the restricted sense of knowledge and meditation respectively. Only those doctrines of Sāṅkhya and Yoga which do not clash with Advaita are accepted by Śaṅkara.

Śaṅkara calls Sāṅkhya the ‘principal opponent’ (pradhāna-malla) of Vedānta, and holds that the refutation of Sāṅkhya implicitly carries with it the refutation of the paramāṇu-kāraṇa-vāda and similar doctrines.

Śaṅkara's Prescription: How Sāṅkhya Should Be Corrected

Śaṅkara suggests that Sāṅkhya should, in effect, transform itself along the following lines:

- Let its Prakṛti glide into Māyā;
- Let its Prakṛti-pariṇāma-vāda glide into Brahma-vivarta-vāda;
- Let its satkāryavāda glide into satkāraṇavāda;
- Let its Puruṣa glide into jīva;
- Let its negative kaivalya glide into a positively blissful mokṣa; and
- Instead of maintaining a plurality of Puruṣas — ‘a vast array of sad personalities’ — and thereby creating an unbridgeable chasm between subject and object, it should recognize the non-dual Puruṣa, the Brahman that transcends the subject-object duality altogether.

III. CRITICISM OF ASAT-KĀRYAVĀDA

Śaṅkara believes in sat-kāryavāda, but his interpretation of it differs sharply from Sāṅkhya's. By it he really means satkāraṇavāda: the effect, no doubt, must pre-exist in the cause, but ultimately the effect is not something different from the cause at all. The cause alone is real; the effect is only its appearance. This view is known as vivartavāda.

Points of Agreement and Disagreement with Rival Schools

Śaṅkara agrees with the Śūnyavādins and the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins, against Sāṅkhya, that if the effect were real and really pre-existed in the cause, it would already be an accomplished fact, and its 'production' would be a vain repetition. He also agrees with them, against Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, that if the effect were a sheer non-entity, its production would be as impossible as the production of a hare's horn. (We have already seen that for the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin, 'asatkāryavāda' is in fact a misnomer, since this school does not really advocate the production of a non-entity — for it, reality itself is efficient causation.)

Śaṅkara, however, agrees with the Śūnyavādin, against the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin, in maintaining that causation in a real sense is an impossibility altogether. 'Production' cannot be called the 'own essence' of a thing, since, ultimately, there can be neither production nor destruction nor any momentary entity whatsoever.

The Positive Doctrine: Effect as Appearance of the Cause

The effect, Śaṅkara argues, can never exist independently and outside of the cause, either before or after its manifestation. It cannot, therefore, be said simply that the effect does not pre-exist in the cause; rather, the effect is only an appearance of the cause. Though the effect and the cause are, at bottom, non-different, it is the effect which exists in and depends on the cause, and never the reverse.

Common experience confirms an ordered, non-arbitrary relation between particular causes and particular effects: milk produces curd, clay produces pots, gold produces ornaments. Curd cannot be produced from clay, nor can pots be produced from milk. If it is rejoined that the cause possesses a certain peculiarity (atishaya) by virtue of which only certain effects can arise from certain causes, Śaṅkara replies with a dilemma: if this 'peculiarity' means simply 'the antecedent condition of the effect,' then asatkāryavāda has already been abandoned (since the effect's antecedent condition just is its pre-existence); and if it means 'the power of the cause to produce a particular determined effect,' then it must be admitted that this power is neither different from the cause nor non-existent in it — for if it were either, production would be impossible.

Cause-Effect Relation is Identity (Tādātmya), not Inherence (Samavāya)

The relation between cause and effect — like that between substance and qualities — must be one of identity (tādātmya). It cannot be one of inherence (samavāya), because inherence would itself require another relation to relate it to the cause and the effect, and that further relation would require yet another, and so on ad infinitum; or else inherence itself, unrelated to its two terms, would be left simply hanging in the air.

Two Further Objections to Asatkāryavāda

(i) The Impossibility of Connexion. According to asatkāryavāda, cause and effect can have no connexion at all, because connexion is possible only between two existent entities, and not between an existent and a non-existent entity, nor between two non-existent entities. Nobody says that the son of a barren woman was once a king: he is a pure non-entity, and never was, is, or will be a king.

(ii) The Cause is Never Destroyed. The theory that the cause is destroyed when the effect is produced is absolutely wrong. When milk changes into curd, the milk is not destroyed. Nor is the seed destroyed when it becomes the sprout. If the cause, in the very process of change, were destroyed, recognition (of the identity underlying the change) would become altogether impossible.

Conclusion: It is impossible to produce an effect which is different from its cause and which does not already pre-exist in it — even within a hundred years.

IV. CRITICISM OF THE PARAMĀṆU-KĀRAṆA-VĀDA OF NYĀYA-VAISHEṢIKA

The Vaisheṣika Doctrine

This school maintains that the four substances — earth, water, fire and air — in their subtle (amūrta) form, are eternal and atomic causes. Ākāsha, though itself not atomic, binds the atoms together. Unlike the atoms of Democritus, which are only quantitatively different, are always in motion, and make up souls as well, the Vaisheṣika atoms are both quantitatively and qualitatively different, are by nature at rest, and are wholly distinct from souls.

God, assisted by the Unseen Power (adrṣṭa) of the jīvas, generates motion in the atoms. This motion (parispanda) joins two atoms together to form a dyad (dvyaṇuka); three such dyads form a triad (tryaṇuka); four dyads form a quartrad (chaturaṇuka); and so on, until the gross objects of the world are produced. An atom is infinitesimal and spherical (parimaṇḍala); a dyad is minute (aṇu) and short (hrasva); a triad and beyond are great (mahat) and long (dīrgha). The things thus produced are not mere aggregates but genuine wholes composed of parts, the parts and the whole being related by inherence (samavāya).

The Vaisheṣika holds that the cause must transmit its qualities to the effect — e.g., white threads make white cloth, black threads make black cloth. Therefore, they argue, the conscious Brahman cannot be the cause of the unconscious world; atoms alone can be its cause.

Śaṅkara's Refutation

1. The premise itself is false: not all qualities are transmitted. It is not necessary for the cause to transmit all its qualities to the effect. Even on the Vaisheṣika's own hypothesis, a spherical atom produces a dyad that is not spherical, but minute and short; and a dyad produces a triad that is neither minute nor short, but great and long. If a spherical cause can produce a non-spherical effect within the Vaisheṣika's own system, why, then, should not the conscious Brahman produce an unconscious world?

2. The dilemma of atomic activity. Are the atoms essentially active, or inactive, or both, or neither?

- If active, creation would become permanent (uninterrupted).
- If inactive, there would be no creation at all.
- If both, the conception is self-contradictory.
- If neither, their activity must come from outside — and this outside agency must be either seen or unseen. If seen, it should not exist prior to creation (so cannot explain the start of creation). If unseen (adṛṣṭa), then, being always present near the atoms, creation would become permanent; and if the proximity of this unseen power to the atoms is instead denied, then creation becomes impossible altogether.

Conclusion: in every alternative, no creation from atoms is possible.

V. CRITICISM OF THE CATEGORIES OF NYĀYA-VAISHEṢIKA

The Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika school assumes six categories (padārtha) which, unlike the Aristotelian categories (mere logical predicates), are treated as metaphysical objects. These categories are said to be absolutely different from one another, and yet it is also maintained that qualities, actions, etc. depend upon substance.

The Substance-Quality Problem

If qualities depend on substance in this way, substance alone should, strictly, exist. To avoid this difficulty, it is maintained that substance and qualities are inseparably connected (ayutasiddha). But this inseparable connection must obtain either in space, or in time, or in the things themselves — and none of these alternatives can support the Vaiśeṣika theory:

- If inseparable in space, the Vaiśeṣika's own doctrine that 'substances produce other substances and qualities produce other qualities' is upset.
- If inseparable in time, then the two horns of a cow would have to be regarded as inseparably connected (an absurd consequence).
- If inseparable in itself, then no distinction whatsoever could be made between substance and qualities.

The Whole and Its Parts

Śaṅkara, like Nāgārjuna, Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita, challenges the very distinction of parts and whole. The whole can be neither a mere aggregate of parts, nor something apart from the parts:

- The whole cannot abide in all the parts taken together, for then it would never be perceived, since it is impossible to perceive all the parts at once.
- If it is said that the whole abides in all the parts taken together — with the help of other parts — this leads to infinite regress, since we would always be forced to assume yet further parts.
- The whole cannot abide in each separate part either, because if it abides wholly in one part, it cannot also abide in another part — just as Devadatta cannot be present,

whole and entire, in two different places at the same time.

- If the whole were present in separate parts (i.e., distributed), it would become many 'wholes' rather than one whole.

Here a fine distinction is drawn between schools: for Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita, the whole is unreal and the parts alone are real; but for Nāgārjuna and for Śāṅkara, both the whole and the parts are merely relative, and therefore ultimately equally unreal.

The Ātman as an Unintelligent Substance Made Intelligent by Contact

Vaiśeṣika maintains that Ātman is a substance which is unintelligent in itself, and becomes intelligent only on account of its contact with mind (manas). Śāṅkara calls this highly absurd: to say that the unqualified and indeterminate Ātman really comes into contact with something wholly different from itself is to violate the established canon of logic. Moreover, either the qualities of pleasure, pain, etc. must be reduced to (i.e., become properties of) the Ātman itself — in which case they too would become permanent, which they plainly are not — or the Ātman must be reduced to these qualities, in which case the Ātman itself would become impermanent. By no stretch of reasoning, Śāṅkara concludes, can it be proved that the Ātman feels pleasure or pain, or that it is made up of parts, or that it is subject to change.

Action, Motion, and the Impossibility of Creation from Atoms

Action or motion (karma) is impossible — and with it, creation too — because the adṛṣṭa can produce no motion whatsoever in the atoms; it can inhere neither in souls nor in atoms. Hence there can be neither creation nor dissolution on this hypothesis.

The Unreality of the Universal

The universal (sāmānya) is, ultimately, also unreal. We never actually perceive any 'universal cow' residing in individual cows — what we perceive are simply the generic qualities present in each individual cow. If the 'universal cow,' conceived as a whole, were really present in each and every cow, then even the horns or the tail of a cow should be able to yield milk (since the whole 'cowness', including the milk-yielding function, would be fully present there too).

The Impossibility of Inherence (Samavāya)

In Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, samavāya (inherence) is a category, while saṃyoga (conjunction) is merely a quality. Inherence is regarded as an eternal, imperceptible, inseparable, real relation subsisting between parts and whole, quality and substance, action and agent, universal and particular, and so on — for instance, a dyad is supposed to be related to its two constituent atoms by this very samavāya.

Śāṅkara — like Chandrakīrti, Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita in the Buddhist tradition, and like Zeno and Bradley in the West — points out that inherence must lead to infinite regress. Inherence, being different from the two things which it relates, itself stands in need of another inherence to relate it with them; this second inherence again requires a further inherence to relate it to its terms, and so on ad infinitum.

If it is maintained instead that samavāya does not inhere in the samavāyin (the thing it relates) by means of a further samavāya, but is simply identical with it, then, by parity of reasoning, saṃyoga too should be regarded as identical with the things it conjoins;

and since both relations would then equally require another relation to relate them to their two terms, merely labelling samavāya a 'category' and saṃyoga a 'quality' cannot remove the difficulty.

Śaṅkara's general logical point is this: a relation, whatever its nature and howsoever intimate it may be conceived to be, can never be identical with the very terms which it relates. If t_1 and t_2 are two terms to be related by a relation r , the following difficulties are bound to arise:

- (1) If r inheres in t_1 , it cannot relate it with t_2 ;
- (2) If r inheres in t_2 , it cannot relate it with t_1 ;
- (3) The very same r cannot inhere simultaneously in both t_1 and t_2 ;
- (4) If r is absolutely different from both t_1 and t_2 , and falls outside both, then r itself becomes another, third term, and requires yet a further relation to relate it with t_1 and t_2 — and thus infinite regress is bound to creep in.

Thus the very distinction between saṃyoga and samavāya proves untenable: one and the same thing may quite legitimately be called by different names according to different considerations, just as the very same Devadatta may be called a Brāhmaṇa, a learned man, a gentleman, a boy, a youth, an old man, a father, a son, a grandson, a brother, a son-in-law, and so on — without any of this multiplying his real, single identity into distinct entities requiring distinct binding relations.

Conclusion: the six categories of Vaiśeṣika are nothing but mere assumptions; and if we are willing to proceed merely on assumptions, there is nothing to check us from assuming hundreds or thousands of categories instead of six.

VI. CRITICISM OF THE DOCTRINE THAT GOD IS THE EFFICIENT CAUSE ONLY

Some Yogins, some Vaiśeṣikas, and others hold that God is only the efficient cause of the world — that He is merely the ruler of eternally pre-existing Primordial Matter and Souls, not their material source. Śaṅkara finds this position untenable on several grounds:

1. The Charge of Partiality. If God is merely a ruler who makes some persons great, some ordinary, and some low, purely according to His own sweet will, then He would rightly be charged with partiality, attachment and hatred — He would become a being just like us, and not a true God at all.
2. The Regress of a Beginningless Series is No Solution. Nor can this difficulty be removed by supposing that the actions of persons and the results given by God form a beginningless series (so that inequality is always explained by prior karma). For then that series would be nothing but a line of the blind led by the blind — explaining nothing at its root.
3. The Impossibility of the Required Connection. God cannot be the ruler of Matter and Souls without being connected with them in some way — yet no such connection is conceivable:
 - It cannot be conjunction (saṃyoga), because God, Souls and Matter are all regarded, on this view, as infinite and without parts (and partless infinities cannot

conjoin).

– It cannot be inherence, because it is impossible to decide which of the two would be the abode and which the abiding thing.

– (Śaṅkara notes that this whole difficulty does not arise at all within his own system, because he maintains the identity, *tādātmya*, of cause and effect from the outset.)

4. The Problem of Finitude at Liberation, and of Multiple Infinities. Again, if *Prakṛti* ceases to exist for the liberated soul, there would be nothing left for God to rule over; it must, therefore, be finite. Moreover, these three supposedly infinite principles — God, Souls and Matter — would limit one another and thereby collapse into a mere void, since the infinite, properly speaking, can only be one.

5. Loss of Omniscience and Omnipotence. Furthermore, if Matter and Souls really are infinite (in the plural), God cannot rule over them at all — and He would then be neither omniscient nor omnipotent.

VII. CRITICISM OF BRAHMA-PARIṆĀMA-VĀDA

Śaṅkara's Own Position: *Brahma-Kāraṇa-Vāda* as *Vivarta*, not *Pariṇāma*

Śaṅkara maintains *Brahma-kāraṇa-vāda*, recognizing Brahman as the cause of the world. But his particular theory is called *Brahma-vivarta-vāda*, because it takes the world to be only a phenomenal appearance of Brahman. Śaṅkara is expressly opposed to *Brahma-pariṇāma-vāda* (the doctrine of Brahman's real transformation). For him, the world is neither a real creation by Brahman, nor a real modification of Brahman.

Brahman, associated with its power *Māyā*, is the ground on which the phenomenal world is superimposed. When true knowledge dawns and the essential unity of the *jīvātman* with the *Paramātman* is realized, the world is sublated.

Pariṇāma versus Vivarta

- *Pariṇāma* (or *vikāra*) — modification or change in a realistic manner (*satattvato'nyathā prathā*), as when gold changes into ornaments, or clay into pots, or milk into curd.
- *Vivarta* — an unreal change, or merely seeming modification (*atattvato'nyathā prathā*), as when water appears in the form of waves, bubbles, or foam.

Sharma notes, following *Sarvajñātma Muni*, that these two are not absolutely opposed: *pariṇāmavāda* logically leads on to *vivartavāda*, of which it is only one step short. The world cannot be called real either at the beginning or at the end, and therefore, in the middle too, it must be unreal.

Brahman as Both Material and Efficient Cause

This entire diverse universe of names and forms, of agents and enjoyers, of space, time and causality, proceeds, says Śaṅkara, from that omniscient, omnipotent and omnipresent cause, the Brahman, which alone is the creator, preserver and destroyer of it. Brahman is the material cause as well as the efficient cause. All the sacred texts which speak of Brahman as undergoing modification or change (pariṇāma) do not mean this literally — a real change in Brahman would be illogical. Their real aim is to teach that the world is only a phenomenal appearance of Brahman, which is in fact beyond all plurality and phenomena, and identical with the Real Self. Thus Īshvara, or Saguṇa Brahman associated with Māyā, is the cause of this world.

Replies to Śāntarakṣita's Objections

Objection 1 — the spider simile. Some object to the Upaniṣadic simile that just as a spider produces, maintains, and devours a cobweb, so Brahman creates, maintains and destroys the world: a spider, they say, emits saliva to produce its web out of desire to eat small insects; but what conceivable desire, and what external means, could Brahman possibly have? Reply: creation is not ultimately real at all — it is only an appearance. Moreover, being Consciousness, Brahman needs no external means beyond its own potency, Māyā.

Objection 2 — inequality and cruelty. It is objected that Īshvara cannot be the creator of this world, since the charges of inequality and cruelty would then fall upon Him: why should He make some people happy and others miserable? Is He not partial to some, and prejudiced against others? Reply: He cannot be so charged. The Shruti and the Smṛti declare that inequality in creation is due to the merits and demerits of the creatures themselves. Just as a cloud rains down the very same water everywhere, yet different seeds fructify differently according to their different potentialities, so Īshvara is the common cause of creation, though different creatures reap different fruits owing to the difference in their own past actions.

Objection 3 — the beginninglessness reply itself is invalid? It might be objected that before creation, merits and demerits do not yet exist (so this explanation cannot get started). This objection is itself invalid, for creation has no beginning: actions and inequality, like seeds and sprouts, are both cause and effect of one another in a beginningless reciprocal series.

The Final Word: Creation is Ultimately Impossible

It should be remembered, however, that ultimately even creation itself is an impossibility. Here Śaṅkara agrees with the Śūnyavādins and with Gauḍapāda. Brahman is the only Reality:

- Brahman cannot be produced from itself, because there can be neither any peculiarity (atishaya) nor any change (vikāra) in the eternal.
- Brahman cannot be produced from anything other than itself, because everything other than Brahman is, in the last analysis, non-existent and unreal.
- Why, then, should Brahman really create at all? It has no desire or ambition left to fulfil — and if it did, it would not be perfect. No desire or ambition on Brahman's part can be proved either by independent reasoning or by the Shruti (Āptakāmasya kā sprhā? — 'what desire can there be for one whose every desire is already fulfilled?').

Therefore, whenever we speak of ‘creation,’ we must remember that we do not mean real creation; we mean only a phenomenal appearance of Brahman, due to Avidyā — and this creation-appearance is real only for as long as Avidyā lasts. When Avidyā is finally removed by right knowledge, God the Ruler, the Soul, the Enjoyer, and the World, the Enjoyed — all are merged, without remainder, in the Highest Brahman.

VIII. CRITICISM OF JAINISM

The Jaina Sapta-bhaṅgī-naya (Syādvāda)

The Jainas believe in a theory of Relativity called the Sapta-bhaṅgī-naya or Syādvāda, comprising seven modes of predication:

- (1) Relatively, it is;
- (2) Relatively, it is not;
- (3) Relatively, it both is and is not;
- (4) Relatively, it is indescribable;
- (5) Relatively, it is and is indescribable;
- (6) Relatively, it is not and is indescribable;
- (7) Relatively, it both is and is not, and is also indescribable.

The Jainas also hold, correspondingly, that a thing may be one as well as many, and eternal as well as momentary (each relatively to a given standpoint).

Śaṅkara's Objections

Śaṅkara, like Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita before him, bitterly criticizes this theory:

1. Contradictory attributes — existence and non-existence, unity and plurality, eternity and momentariness — cannot belong to the very same thing at the same time, just as light and darkness cannot occupy the same place, or the same thing cannot be simultaneously hot and cold.
 2. By its own logic, the theory of Syādvāda itself may then not be correct either (a self-referential difficulty).
 3. Relativity cannot be sustained at all without presupposing some Absolute — and it is precisely such an Absolute which the Jainas reject.
 4. The theory, Śaṅkara says pointedly, looks like the words of a lunatic.
 5. The judgments in question cannot really be ‘indescribable,’ for they are, after all, clearly set forth in words. To describe a thing and simultaneously to say that it is indescribable is a plain contradiction in terms.
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IX. CRITICISM OF BUDDHISM

(a) Criticism of the Sarvāstivāda School

The Sarvāstivāda is the most important school of Hīnayāna. It is divided, according to Śaṅkara, into two major sub-schools:

- Vaibhāṣika — attaches itself to the Vibhāṣā, a Commentary on an Abhidharma work; it may be called presentationism, or naïve realism, since it maintains the independent existence of mind and matter.
- Sautrāntika — attaches itself to the Sūtra; it may be called representationism, or critical realism, since it maintains that the existence of external objects is only inferred through mental presentations — much as the eating of good food is inferred from corpulence, or a country is inferred through its characteristic language.

Both schools, however, are equally realistic, and both reduce mind to a series of fleeting ideas, and matter to a series of fleeting sensations.

Śaṅkara groups both schools together under the single name 'Sarvāstivāda,' and states that its followers hold external reality to be either element (bhūta) or elemental (bhautika), and internal reality to be either mind (chitta) or mental (chaitta). Earth, water, fire and air are the elements; colour, etc., and the sense-organs such as the eye, are elemental. The internal world consists of the five skandhas — of sensation, idea, feeling, conception, and forces.

Śaṅkara's Objections to Sarvāstivāda

1. Neither type of aggregate — external nor internal — can ever be formed at all. Unintelligent momentary atoms and momentary skandhas cannot, by themselves, form any systematic whole. No intelligent principle — no enjoyer or ruler capable of uniting these aggregates — is admitted by the Buddhist opponents themselves.
2. If it is urged that the momentary vijñāna (consciousness) itself unites the aggregates, this is untenable: the vijñāna must come into existence in the first moment, and must unite the aggregates only in the second moment — which would mean the vijñāna exists for at least two moments, and is therefore not, after all, momentary.
3. Nor can the aggregates be formed on account of Dependent Origination (Pratītyasamutpāda), for in the Wheel of Causation each preceding link is the immediate efficient cause only of the single succeeding link, and not of the whole series taken together.
4. The momentary atoms cannot combine by themselves either: if it is impossible even for the permanent atoms of the Vaiśeṣika to combine (as shown in Section IV), it is all the more impossible for the merely momentary atoms posited by Buddhism.
5. A further objection concerns the Buddhist claim that existence arises out of non-existence — that a seed must be destroyed before a sprout can spring up, or milk destroyed before curd can come into being. Śaṅkara replies that an entity can never arise from a non-entity. Had this been possible, anything would arise from anything whatsoever — yet nothing can ever originate from the horns of a hare. And even when the Buddhists themselves admit that aggregates arise from atoms, and mental states from the skandhas (i.e., that something must already be there to give rise to something else), why, Śaṅkara asks, should they go on to confuse the world with such needless contradictions?

(b) Criticism of the Theory of Momentariness (Kṣaṇabhaṅga-vāda)

The antecedent link in a causal series, Śaṅkara argues, cannot even be regarded as the efficient cause of the subsequent link, because on the theory of momentariness, the preceding link ceases to exist at the very moment the subsequent link arises.

Two failed rescues considered:

- If it is urged that the antecedent moment, once fully developed (pariṇiṣpannāvasthāḥ), becomes the cause of the subsequent moment, this is untenable, because the assertion that a fully developed moment possesses causal efficiency necessarily presupposes its connection with the second moment — which repudiates the very theory of universal momentariness it was meant to save.
- If it is urged instead (as the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins do) that the mere existence of the preceding moment already constitutes its causal efficiency (bhāva evāśya vyāpāraḥ), this too is impossible, because no effect can arise without imbibing the very nature of its cause — and to admit this is to admit that the cause is, in fact, permanent, since it continues to exist within the effect. This once again throws overboard the doctrine of momentariness.

The Dilemma of Production and Destruction

Are production and destruction the very nature of a thing itself (vastunaḥ svarūpameva), or another state of it (avasthāntaram vā), or an altogether different thing (vastvantaram vā)? All three alternatives fail:

- If identical with the thing itself, production and destruction would simply become synonymous with the thing.
- If production is the beginning, the thing the middle, and destruction the end, then the thing, being connected across three moments, would not be momentary at all.
- If production and destruction are held to be two absolutely different things (like, say, a horse and a buffalo), then the thing itself, being different from both production and destruction, would become permanent.
- If production and destruction are regarded merely as perception and non-perception (of the thing), then, since perception and non-perception are attributes of the perceiving mind and not of the thing itself, the thing would again turn out to be permanent.

In every case, therefore, the theory of momentariness proves entirely untenable.

Further Difficulties

If the opponent claims that things arise without any cause, he directly violates his own stated principle that things arise depending on causes and conditions — and then, absurdly, anything might arise out of anything. If, instead, the opponent says that the preceding cause lasts only up to the very arising of the succeeding effect, this would imply that cause and effect are in fact simultaneous.

Moreover, there can be neither conscious destruction (pratisaṅkhyā-nirodha — e.g., a jar destroyed by a stick) nor unconscious destruction (apratisaṅkhyā-nirodha — e.g., the natural decay of things), because these can be related neither to the causal series (sāntāna-gochara, since within any such series the members are causally related in an uninterrupted manner) nor to the individual members of the series (bhāva-gochara,

since a momentary thing cannot be said to be completely annihilated when it is in fact recognized, across different states, as having a connected existence).

If Ignorance is destroyed by Right Knowledge, then the Buddhistic doctrine that universal destruction proceeds without any cause has already been abandoned; and if Ignorance is instead destroyed 'by itself,' then the entire Buddhist teaching regarding the 'Path' meant to help destroy Ignorance becomes futile and pointless.

Bondage and liberation, too, become impossible if the soul itself is momentary: whose, then, is the bondage, and whose the liberation? There would also be a kind of vicarious moral liability, since the one who performs an act would lose its fruit, while another — a different momentary entity entirely — would have to reap it.

The Argument from Memory and Recognition

The fact of memory and recognition, Śāṅkara holds, deals a death-blow to the entire theory of momentariness. The past is recognized and remembered in the present, and this necessarily implies the existence of a permanent synthesizing subject, without whom knowledge across time would remain forever impossible. Identity cannot be reduced to mere similarity: even similarity requires a permanent subject who is able to know two separate things as being similar to one another. When the Buddhist himself recognizes all his own successive cognitions, right up to his last breath, as belonging to one and the same Self, should he not tremble at maintaining, so shamelessly, the doctrine of momentariness? Everything may in principle be doubted, but the self can never be doubted, for the very idea of doubt already presupposes the existence of the self that doubts.

Indeed, Śāṅkara observes, when philosophers fail to admit a self-evident fact of this kind, they may try, in various ways, to uphold their own view and refute their opponent's — but in doing so they only entangle themselves in mere words, and, honestly speaking, convince neither their opponents nor even themselves.

(c) Criticism of 'Vijñānavāda' (Really of Svatantra-Vijñānavāda)

By the term 'Vijñānavāda,' Śāṅkara really means Svatantra-Vijñānavāda. These Buddhists, he says, maintain the existence of momentary ideas alone. They hold that the Buddha taught the reality of the external world only to his inferior disciples, who still cling to this world, while to his superior disciples he gave his real, esoteric teaching — that ultimate reality is nothing but momentary vijñāna (consciousness).

Śāṅkara, taking his stand mainly on the Ālambanaparīkṣā of Dinnāga, exposes the Buddhist idealist view as follows: if external things exist, they must be either atoms, or aggregates of atoms (such as posts, etc.) — and both alternatives are impossible. Atoms cannot themselves be perceived, and their aggregates can be regarded neither as identical with the atoms, nor as different from them. It is, rather, the ideas themselves which appear as the various external objects — as a post, a wall, a pot, a cloth, and so on. That the idea is in fact identical with the external object is further proved, on this view, by the rule that the internal idea and the external object are always experienced simultaneously — *esse est percipi* (sahopalambhaniyama).

On this idealist view, there is supposedly no real difference between the waking and the dreaming states: just as in dreams, magical illusions, mirages, castles in the sky, etc., it is the ideas themselves which appear as objects, though no external objects in fact exist there, so too in the waking state, the ideas themselves merely appear as

external objects. The plurality of ideas is attributed to beginningless impressions (anādi vāsanā), and not to any plurality of so-called external objects; and within beginningless saṃsāra, ideas and impressions are held to succeed one another, like seeds and sprouts, as causes and effects.

Śaṅkara's Refutation — Psychological Realism against Subjective Idealism

Śaṅkara vehemently criticizes this view as a form of subjective idealism, and the tragedy is, he suggests, heightened by the fact that these ideas are further held to be merely momentary. Śaṅkara's own standpoint here is what Sharma calls psychological realism, which is entirely compatible with Absolute Idealism at the metaphysical level.

- The external world must exist, quite simply, because we perceive it.
- If things and ideas are presented together in experience, this does not mean that they are therefore identical.
- If objects depend upon the mind (for their manifestation), this does not mean that they are thereby a part of the mind. To be perceived by the mind is not the same as to be a portion of the mind.
- The Buddhist's arguments denying the external world — even while he is himself constantly experiencing it — are like the words of a person who, while actually eating and feeling satisfied, insists that he is not eating or feeling satisfied at all.
- We perceive a black cow and a white cow. The attributes of blackness and whiteness may certainly differ, yet 'cowness' remains the same across both. Similarly, in the 'cognition of a jar' and the 'cognition of a cloth,' the jar and the cloth, as objects, clearly differ, while the consciousness (of them) remains the same throughout. This proves that ideas and their objects are genuinely distinct from one another.

Answering the Idealist's Fallback Position

If the Buddhist replies that he is not really denying the consciousness of objects, but only asserting that he perceives no object apart from consciousness, Śaṅkara answers that this is merely a purely arbitrary statement, which the Buddhist cannot prove by any sound argument whatsoever. Nobody is conscious of his own perception alone; everybody, in fact, perceives external objects like a post, a wall, and so on. Even the Buddhist, while explicitly denying the external object in his philosophy, implicitly accepts it in every act of ordinary life.

Diṇnāga himself says that 'internal consciousness itself appears as if it is something external.' Now, Śaṅkara asks, if there really is no external world at all, how can Diṇnāga meaningfully say that consciousness appears as if it were something external? Indeed, no sane person ever says that Viṣṇumitra appears like the son of a barren woman (a pure non-entity), for there can be no hypothetical comparison without a genuine categorical basis. Possibility, in other words, always involves an actuality. The possibility or impossibility of things can be determined only through the valid means of right knowledge; and the means of right knowledge themselves do not depend upon any pre-conceived notion of possibility or impossibility. That is possible which can be proved by some valid means of cognition, such as perception; and that is impossible which cannot be so proved. Since the external objects are, in fact, apprehended by all the valid means of cognition, how, Śaṅkara asks, can their existence be legitimately denied?

Śaṅkara also quotes a verse of Dharmakīrti, to the effect that ‘non-dual consciousness itself is wrongly viewed as if it appears as the subject-object duality.’ Śaṅkara criticizes this view from the very same standpoint from which he criticizes Dinnāga: he objects specifically to the phrase as if external. The Buddhists, he insists, should rather say that Consciousness genuinely appears as the external world, and not merely that it appears as if it were something external. In thus objecting, Śaṅkara himself effectively admits that the entire subject-object universe is only an appearance of the Ātman, which is Pure Consciousness — his point being simply to reject subjective idealism, while at the same time emphasizing the full phenomenal reality of the external world.

Dream and Waking States are Not on a Par

Śaṅkara further emphasizes that the dream state and the waking state cannot be placed on an equal footing, as the Vijñānavādin supposes. These states are, in fact, entirely different in character:

- Things seen in a dream are sublated precisely in the waking state; their falsity and illusory character are realized only when the dreamer awakes. But things like posts and walls, seen in the waking state, are not similarly contradicted or sublated by any further state.
- Dreams are private; waking life, by contrast, is public.
- Things in dreams are merely remembered afterward; things in waking life are directly perceived as they occur.

These two states, therefore, cannot be treated as being on the same level merely on the pretext that both are, in some general sense, ‘experienced through consciousness.’ Even the Buddhist himself, in practice, recognizes the acute difference between the two — a difference that cannot be explained away by mere intellectual jugglery.

The Impossibility of Beginningless Impressions Without Real Objects

The Buddhist assertion that the plurality of ideas is due only to the plurality of impressions, and not to any plurality of external objects, is also mistaken, because if external objects did not exist at all, the impressions themselves could never have arisen in the first place. And even if these impressions are held to be beginningless, this position is really like a series of the blind leading the blind — it leads to the fallacy of infinite regress, and at once negates all the practical affairs (vyavahāra) of the world. Moreover, impressions, being mental modifications, require some substratum in which to inhere — and in the Buddhistic view, there is no such substratum available. Even the Ālayavijñāna, since it too is held to be momentary, cannot itself serve as the substratum of these impressions, any more than the individual, momentary cognitions (pravṛttivijñānas) can.

Śaṅkara adds that his earlier criticism of the theory of momentariness (Section IX-b) applies equally and fully to this Vijñānavādin school as well.

Momentary Ideas Cannot Synthesize Themselves

Momentary ideas cannot ideate themselves. There must be a permanent self to synthesize the fleeting ideas and give them unity and meaning; the preceding and succeeding ideas each become extinct as soon as they become objects of consciousness, and can, therefore, neither apprehend anything, nor be apprehended by anything else on their own terms. Hence, Śaṅkara concludes, the various Buddhistic theories — fleeting ideas succeeding one another, momentariness, the doctrine of the Unique Particular and the General, the theory that the preceding idea leaves an impression which causes the succeeding idea to arise, the theory of Ignorance, the theory of the Existence and Non-Existence of things, the theory of Bondage and Liberation — all crumble down together.

If the Buddhist replies that the idea is self-conscious, apprehending itself as a luminous lamp apprehends itself, he is wrong, for to say that a momentary idea illuminates itself is as absurd as saying that fire burns itself. If he urges instead that to say an idea is apprehended by something else involves one in an infinite regress (since that other thing would itself require yet another thing to apprehend it), and that therefore the only way to avoid this regress is to hold that the idea is self-luminous like a lamp — both of these arguments, Śaṅkara says, are fallacious.

In fact, it is only the permanent self which apprehends the manifold ideas and synthesizes them into a unity, and this self alone may properly be regarded as self-luminous, like a lamp needing nothing else for its own illumination. But an idea itself cannot be so regarded: an idea is always apprehended by the self. An idea is, in this respect, exactly like an object, standing in relation to the knowing self, which is the true subject. Since the self, which apprehends the ideas, requires nothing else for its own apprehension, the charge of infinite regress simply does not arise for it — and so the Buddhist's second objection, too, becomes ineffective.

The self alone is the knowing subject; an idea is only ever a known object. The witnessing self is a self-evident fact: its existence is self-proved, and can never be denied by anyone (since the very act of denial presupposes a self doing the denying). The view that a momentary idea, like a lamp, manifests itself without being illuminated by the self, effectively means that knowledge is possible without any knowing subject at all — which is as absurd as maintaining that a thousand lamps might manifest themselves inside a deep, impenetrable rock, with no one present to see them.

If the Buddhist says that by 'idea' he really means consciousness itself, and that we Vedāntins, too, who accept the ultimate reality of consciousness, must therefore accept his view, he is utterly mistaken — because for the Vedāntin, an idea is only ever like an object, requiring for its own manifestation the self-luminous Self which is the true knower. And if the Buddhist rejoins that our witnessing Self, said to be self-luminous and self-proved, is really just his own 'idea' in disguise, he is again wrong: for whereas his ideas are momentary and manifold, no better than a scattered chaos endlessly originating and dying away, our Self, by contrast, is non-dual and permanent, the ultimate knowing subject which synthesizes these scattered ideas into a unity and gives them meaning. Therefore, Śaṅkara concludes, the fundamental difficulty in Buddhism is not removed even if we grant self-consciousness to the vijñānas themselves, for the vijñānas, being momentary and manifold, will only add further to the confusion. It is only the Self — the permanent knower and the eternal seer whose sight is never destroyed — that can serve this synthesizing function; and even hundreds of Buddhists

together cannot disprove this self-proved self, nor can they replace it with their own momentary idea, any more than a dead person can be brought back to life again.

The Buddhist Idealist's Own Formulation, and its Consequences

These Buddhists believe, Śaṅkara notes, that knowledge itself, being self-luminous consciousness (chitsvarūpābhāsakatvena), appears in its own form as the subject (svākārā), as well as in the form of external objects (viṣayākārā cha) — that it is the idea (vijñāna) itself which manifests as both subject and object (grāhyagrāhakākārā), and that this transparent (svachchhībhūtam) and momentary (kṣaṇikam) idea (vijñānam) ultimately transcends the subject-object duality altogether (grāhyagrāhaka-vinirmuktam).

Śaṅkara treats all of these assumptions as obstacles to the Vedic path leading to the Highest Good:

- The illumination of a lamp is never its own; it comes from the (perceiving) self. In this precise respect, there is no difference at all between a pot and a lamp — both are equally mere objects. Thus the momentary vijñāna, being only an object to the self that knows it, cannot possibly manifest itself as the subject-object duality; the momentary vijñānas must themselves be known by the self (vijñānasyāpi chaitanyagrāhyatvāt). This self, which knows the manifold vijñānas and gives them unity and meaning, is different from them, and is the only true light, the only self-luminous knower.
- If ideas alone were real, they would be exactly synonymous with pots, cloths, and the like, since all of them are equally objects to the knowing self. This would lead to the total abolition of the distinction between subject and object, between means and end, between actions and their results, and would further lead to the annihilation of all phenomenal practices whatsoever (sarva-samvyavahāralopaprasaṅgaḥ).
- Bondage and Liberation would themselves become impossible.
- The sacred texts of the Buddhists would become useless (upadesha-shāstrānarthakya-prasaṅgaḥ), and their authors would have to be regarded as ignorant (tatkarturajñāna-prasaṅgaḥ).
- There would also result a kind of vicarious liability (akṛtābhyāgama) and the destruction of one's own deeds without fruit (kṛtavipranaṣha).
- If the self-conscious vijñāna is the only reality, and there is truly no self at all, then the qualities of momentariness, soullessness, etc. could not even be meaningfully imposed upon it. Nor can these qualities be regarded as a mere part of vijñāna, since it is impossible that the qualities which are enjoyed should also be a part of the vijñāna which is itself the enjoyer. Nor, again, can these qualities be natural or intrinsic to vijñāna, for if they were, it would then be impossible ever to remove suffering, and liberation itself would become impossible. Nor, finally, can the mere annihilation of vijñāna be equated with the cessation of suffering — for surely, if a person pierced by a deadly thorn simply dies, he cannot on that account be said to have been cured of the pain produced by that thorn. Death, certainly, is not the remedy for a disease.

(d) Advance on Vijñānavāda and on Gauḍapāda

Sharma now steps back to assess what Śaṅkara has actually accomplished. The view which Śaṅkara exposes and criticizes under the name of 'Vijñānavāda' is, in fact, Svatantra-Vijñānavāda. We do not find in Śaṅkara any reference at all to the doctrines of the Laṅkāvatāra, or to Asaṅga and Vasubandhu proper. What we do find is that Śaṅkara has quoted half a verse from Diṇnāga, one full verse from Dharmakīrti, and has often referred to the views of Śāntarakṣita without, however, mentioning any of these names explicitly. His exposition of 'Vijñānavāda' is, in fact, a correct and clear exposition specifically of Svatantra-Vijñānavāda. It should also be remembered that the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin were Śaṅkara's own immediate predecessors. All these facts together support the view that the so-called criticism of 'Vijñānavāda' by Śaṅkara is really the criticism of the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school; the real Vijñāna-vāda of Asaṅga and Vasubandhu is not, in fact, refuted by it.

Why Śaṅkara's Criticism Loses Force Against Vasubandhu and Gauḍapāda

It may be pointed out that in regard to those particular views which Vijñānavāda genuinely shares in common with Svatantra-Vijñānavāda, Śaṅkara's criticism does apply to Vijñānavāda as well. But it is very important to note that here Śaṅkara's criticism loses much of its force. The Ālambana-Parīkṣā of Diṇnāga is, in fact, not a very original work at all — almost all its ideas are based upon the works of Vasubandhu. We know that Vasubandhu, in his Viṃśatikā and its Bhāṣya, had already criticized the atoms of the Vaiśeṣikas and of the Vaibhāṣikas; we also know that he declared external objects to be, in effect, inside consciousness; and that he placed the dream state and the waking state almost on an equal footing. We further know that Gauḍapāda, too, agreed completely with Vasubandhu in many respects.

Śaṅkara's criticism, therefore, does apply in some respects to Vasubandhu and to Gauḍapāda as well. But Sharma argues that this criticism loses much of its force when directed at them, for two decisive reasons:

Firstly, Vasubandhu and Gauḍapāda do not deny the objectivity of the external world, since for them the objects genuinely appear as objects to the knowing subject (they are not reduced to mere private, subjective states).

Secondly, because they hold pure Consciousness — which is the very same as the self-luminous Self — to be the permanent background of all phenomena. Their view, in short, is not subjective idealism at all; it is absolutism. When it is maintained that pure and permanent Consciousness, self-luminous and transcending the subject-object duality, is the only reality, and that the world is only its appearance, Śaṅkara's own criticism falls off the mark — precisely because Śaṅkara himself believes in this very view.

Difference of Degree, Not of Kind

The difference between Vasubandhu and Gauḍapāda on the one hand, and Śaṅkara on the other, is, Sharma insists, not a difference of kind but only of degree — a difference only of emphasis. We know that Vasubandhu and Gauḍapāda distinguish between the illusory (parikalpita) and the relative (paratantra) aspects of experience; they place these two states on a par with one another only in order to emphasize the ultimate unreality of the world. Śaṅkara, on the other hand, is keen — and, Sharma remarks, herein lies Śaṅkara's own greatness — to emphasize instead the phenomenal reality of the world.

Secondly, Śaṅkara wants to prove the unreality of the external world, not merely by saying that it does not fall outside consciousness, but rather by saying that it is essentially false (mithyā), precisely because it can be described neither as existent nor as non-existent (sadasadanirvachanīya). We have already seen that this particular doctrine was itself accepted by Gauḍapāda and by Śūnyavāda before him.

Thirdly, in Śaṅkara's system, Vasubandhu's Vijnaptimātra gives place to Brahman or Ātman; Ālayavijñāna gives place to Īshvara; Klišṭa-Manovijñāna gives place to Jīva; Viśayavijñapti gives place to Jagat; and Pariṇāma gives place to Vivarta. In this sense, Śaṅkara in fact develops the ideas already found in Śūnyavāda, Vijñānavāda and Gauḍapāda, carrying them almost to perfection and to a spotless purity.

Śaṅkara's criticism, therefore, both applies to, and is genuinely intended by him to apply to, the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school alone — the school which degrades Consciousness to nothing more than momentary and manifold ideas.

(e) Criticism of Śūnyavāda

Śaṅkara takes the word 'Śūnya' in the sense of mere negation, and argues that Śūnyavāda, understood as pure nihilism, is contradicted by all valid means of cognition, and therefore stands self-condemned. The Śūnyavādin, he argues, cannot legitimately negate all phenomenal practices whatsoever unless he can point to some higher truth (anyattattva) that grounds this very negation. Śaṅkara therefore summarily dismisses Śūnyavāda, taking it to be simply below criticism.

But, Sharma adds pointedly, Śūnyavāda in fact does admit precisely such a higher truth (Tattva), and is, properly understood, itself a form of absolutism — a point developed fully in the general assessment below.

(f) General Criticism of Buddhism

The more we examine the Buddhistic system as a whole, Śaṅkara says, the more it gives way, like a well dug in sand. It has no solid foundation; there is no truth in it; it serves no useful purpose. The Buddha, by teaching three mutually contradictory systems — Bāhyārthavāda, Vijñānavāda, and Śūnyavāda — has, in Śaṅkara's view, proved beyond doubt that either:

- he was simply fond of making contradictory statements; or
- his hatred of people led him deliberately to teach three contradictory doctrines, so that people might be utterly confused and deluded by accepting them.

Therefore, Śaṅkara concludes, all persons who genuinely desire the Good should at once reject Buddhism altogether.

Sharma's Own Critical Assessment

Sharma closes the chapter with his own evaluation of Śaṅkara's polemic. We thus see, he writes, that Śaṅkara's attitude towards Buddhism is fundamentally one of hatred and animosity. The generous spirit of Gauḍapāda towards Mahāyāna is, by this point, entirely gone.

As for Śaṅkara's criticism of Buddhism, Sharma offers the following assessment:

- Śaṅkara finds it easy to dismiss Śūnyavāda by taking the word 'Śūnya' in its merely popular sense of pure negation or void. When he remarks that Śūnyavāda cannot dismiss the world either as pure negation or as merely relative existence

unless it can point to some higher truth (tattva), he simply takes it for granted, without argument, that Śūnyavāda possesses no such higher truth. But, Sharma insists, the entire treatment of Śūnyavāda [elsewhere in this book] bears ample witness to the fact that Śūnyavāda declares the world to be relative, and therefore ultimately unreal, precisely because it emphatically believes in the reality of a higher truth or Tattva, which it calls Paramārtha. Śaṅkara, therefore, in Sharma's judgment, only avoids Śūnyavāda — he does not genuinely refute it.

- We have also noticed that Śaṅkara does not, in fact, refute real Vijñānavāda at all (i.e., the authentic Vijñānavāda of Asaṅga and Vasubandhu).
- As far as Bāhyārthavāda or Sarvāstivāda is concerned, we know that this school of Hīnayāna was already bitterly criticized by the Mahāyānists themselves; Śaṅkara's criticism against it, therefore, cannot be regarded as altogether new or original — although it remains, Sharma affirms, perfectly valid.

Sharma's final verdict: the full force of Śaṅkara's criticism is, in the end, directed above all against the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school, and especially against its theory of momentariness. To this extent, and in this specific target, Sharma concludes, the criticism is fully justified.

End of Part I. Section X (“Māyā and Brahman”) and Śaṅkara's own constructive exposition follow in Part II.